Michael West

Visiting Assistant Teaching Professor, Widener University

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Academic Appointments

Widener University *Chester, PA*

Visiting Assistant Teaching Professor, Department of Computer Science *Fall 2026 – Present*

Education

Temple University *Philadelphia, PA*

Ph.D., Computer and Information Science *August 2026*

- Dissertation: *[Dissertation title]*
- Advisor: Dr. Eduard Dragut

Loyola Marymount University *Los Angeles, CA*

B.S., Computer Science *May 2020*

- Dual Major in Psychology

Research Experience

Temple University, Department of Computer and Information Science *Philadelphia, PA*

Graduate Research Assistant; Advisor: Dr. Eduard Dragut *Fall 2021 – Spring 2026*

- Developed PatchScout, a multi-agent LLM framework that frames thematic web data collection as budget-constrained information foraging; outperforms commercial deep-research systems on open-ended entity collection tasks [C3].
- Built an interactive, human-in-the-loop system for thematic data collection on the live web [C2], and proposed structure-aware frontier pruning for focused crawling (under review).
- Developed a data science system to identify postsecondary autism support programs from their websites [J4].
- Conducted 34 stakeholder interviews to examine how autistic students discover and use support programs [J5].
- Contributed to an interdisciplinary NSF-funded project applying AI to improve vocational outcomes for autistic adults [J1, J3].

Loyola Marymount University, Departments of Psychology and Computer Science *Los Angeles, CA*

Undergraduate Research Assistant; Advisors: Dr. Joseph LaBrie, Dr. Andrew Forney *2018 – 2020*

- Led an undergraduate development team to build CampusGANDR, a cross-platform mobile app delivering personalized normative feedback to first-year college students [J2].
- Oversaw deployment to three cohorts of participants across 21 campuses.

Publications

Conference Papers

[C3] **M. West** and E. Dragut. PatchScout: Thematic Web Data Collection via Information Foraging. In *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS)*, 2026. To appear.

[C2] **M. West** and E. Dragut. A Demo of Interactive Thematic Data Collection on the Live Web. *Proceedings of the VLDB Endowment (PVLDB)*, 19(12):4554–4557, 2026. Demonstration track.

[C1] S. Han, H. Ji, Z. Jiang, **M. West**, and M. Liu. What Do Students Want to Know While Taking Massive Open Online Courses? Examining Massive Open Online Course Students' Needs Based on Online Forum Discussions from the Universal Design for Learning Approach. In *Proceedings of the 13th International Learning Analytics and Knowledge Conference (LAK)*, pp. 572–578, 2023.

Journal Articles

[J5] **M. West**, K. Kostin, M. Tincani, D. Hantula, and E. Dragut. Evaluating Autism Support Programs in Higher Education Through the Perspectives of Students, Parents, Counselors and Staff. *Frontiers in Education*, 11:1921007, 2026.

[J4] **M. West**, M. Tincani, D. Hantula, S. R. Hong, S. Vucetic, and E. Dragut. Applying Data Science Practices to Identify Characteristics of Postsecondary Autism Support Programs From Their Websites. *Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders*, 1–47, 2025.

[J3] E. Garrison, S. MacNeil, D. A. Hantula, **M. West**, E. Dragut, M. Tincani, and S. Vucetic. Exploring the Challenges and Assistive Technology for Autistic Job Seekers Across Employment Pathways. *Research in Developmental Disabilities*, 167:105155, 2025.

[J2] J. W. LaBrie, S. C. Boyle, B. M. Trager, N. A. Hall, L. M. Rainosek, O. J. Hatch, **M. J. West**, …, and C. Neighbors. When Less Is More: Short-Term Efficacy of a Gamified Personalized Normative Feedback Intervention for College Students. *Addictive Behaviors*, 163:108247, 2025.

[J1] M. Tincani, H. Ji, M. Upthegrove, E. Garrison, **M. West**, D. Hantula, …, and E. Dragut. Vocational Interventions for Individuals with ASD: Umbrella Review. *Review Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders*, 11(4):806–842, 2024.

Under Review

M. West and E. Dragut. Revisiting Focused Crawling through Structure-Aware Frontier Pruning. Submitted to *The Web Conference (WWW)*.

L. Wang, **M. West**, S. Rustamova, Z. Chen, and E. Dragut. AiO-Meme: An All-in-One Multi-Agent Pipeline for Multi-faceted Meme Understanding. Submitted to *AAAI*.

Teaching Experience

Widener University

Visiting Assistant Teaching Professor — *Fall 2026 – Present*

- Computer Structures and Assembly Language
- Introduction to Programming in Python

Temple University

Instructor of Record and Teaching Assistant — *Fall 2022 – Spring 2026*

- Instructor of Record, Data Structures (Spring 2026)
- Graduate Student Seminar: Core NLP Principles and LLMs (Spring 2025, Fall 2025)
- Teaching Assistant, Introduction to Mobile Application Development; Software Development (Fall 2022, Fall 2025)

Saint John Vianney High School

Teacher — *Fall 2020 – Spring 2021*

- Principles of Engineering

Service

Professional

Reviewer

- Community Mental Health Journal (2026)
- ACM Transactions on Computing for Healthcare (2025)
- Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders (2025)

Institutional

Temple University — *Philadelphia, PA*

College of Science and Technology — *2023 – 2026*

- President, Graduate Student Organization (Spring 2023 – Spring 2026)
- Graduate Student Representative, Dean's Advisory Committee (Fall 2023 – Spring 2026)